

capital expenditures were needed to purchase leases, machinery and equipment and to finance exploration and drilling.

Most oil pools that lay near the surface in known oil belts had been located and were being exploited. It was necessary to prospect ever farther afield and to drill ever deeper to find oil.

There were many mergers and consolidations of oil companies. Some independent operators were falling by the wayside. Others were selling out to big oil companies.

There was also a strange, ominous undercurrent running through the entire U.S. economy. The stock market listed shares at fantastic highs, but there were warnings and forebodings of economic trouble ahead.

It was a critical period for all wildcatters and a particularly difficult one for me. I had to look after my own mushrooming business interests—my own leases, producing wells and companies. Then, through the years, I'd bought sizable blocks of stock in my father's companies as well. Now, his health began to fail, and I found it increasingly necessary to take an active part in managing the operations of these companies.

In 1929, the stock market crashed. The following year, my father suffered a stroke. Although he was over 75, he

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fought death bravely and grimly for several weeks, but the battle was lost on May 31, 1930, when he passed away. My mother and I were allowed but little time to grieve. We had to keep his business going and his companies operating.

The Federal Government pressed for rapid settlement of the inheritance taxes on the estate. These and many other matters demanded immediate attention and all were complicated by the economic factor of the deepening Depression. Many advised me to liquidate everything—to sell out not only my late father's holdings, but my own firms and interests as well.